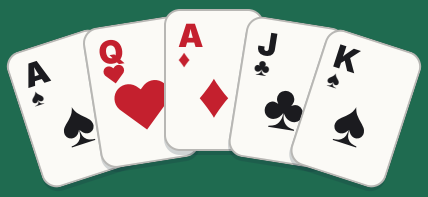
ESCAPE FROM ACE-CATRAZ!





A cooperative card deduction game for 2–4 inmates

2–4	52 + 18	Co-op	0
PLAYERS	CARDS	WIN OR LOSE TOGETHER	PEEKS AT YOUR OWN HAND

OVERVIEW

You and your crew are prisoners in the world's most notorious card-themed prison, **Ace-Catraz**. Security is tight and you can't escape alone.

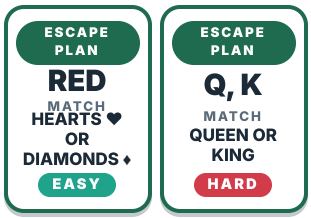
Each player manages a hand of cards, with a twist: you hold your cards **facing outward**. Everyone else can see them. You can't. You must rely on your crew to tell you what you're holding, and sneak past the guards together.

GOAL

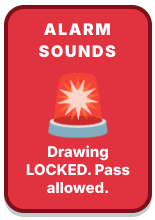
The crew wins if it successfully completes **the entire escape plan**: every obstacle cleared, one card from every player each time.

One wrong card trips the alarm and **everyone** goes back to their cells.

COMPONENTS



17 SECURITY CARDS
(TWO-SIDED: OBSTACLE / GUARD CHECK)



1 ALARM SOUNDS CARD



52-CARD DECK, NO JOKERS
(NOT INCLUDED)

THE THREE KINDS OF SECURITY CARDS



EASY × 6
Match half the deck, such as *odd*, *red* or *high*.



MEDIUM × 6
One suit, or a group of ranks such as *face cards*.



HARD × 5
Only two ranks match, such as *8 or 9*.

1 SETUP

1. **Build the Escape Plan.** Set the **HARD** cards and the Alarm card aside. Add **1** (2 players), **2** (3 players) or **3** (4 players) HARD cards to the Easy and Medium cards, and shuffle. Deal this deck face down in a line in the centre to make the **Obstacles** (see the table).
2. **Create the Patrol Deck.** Shuffle the unused HARD cards into the remaining Security cards. Place this deck next to the Flashlight Deck.
3. **Peek at the lock levels, then choose your escape path.** Look at the Lock Security Level shown on the back of each Obstacle, then agree on a direction: **left-to-right** or **right-to-left**. Flip the first two Obstacles from that end face up. The first is the **active** Obstacle. Start with the hard ones, or save them for later. It's your call.
4. **Prepare the Flashlight Deck.** Shuffle the 52 cards, then place them face down on top of the Alarm Sounds card (a 53-card deck).
5. **Prep the crew.** Deal 5 cards from the top of the Flashlight Deck to each player. **No peeking at your own cards.** Hold them facing outward.

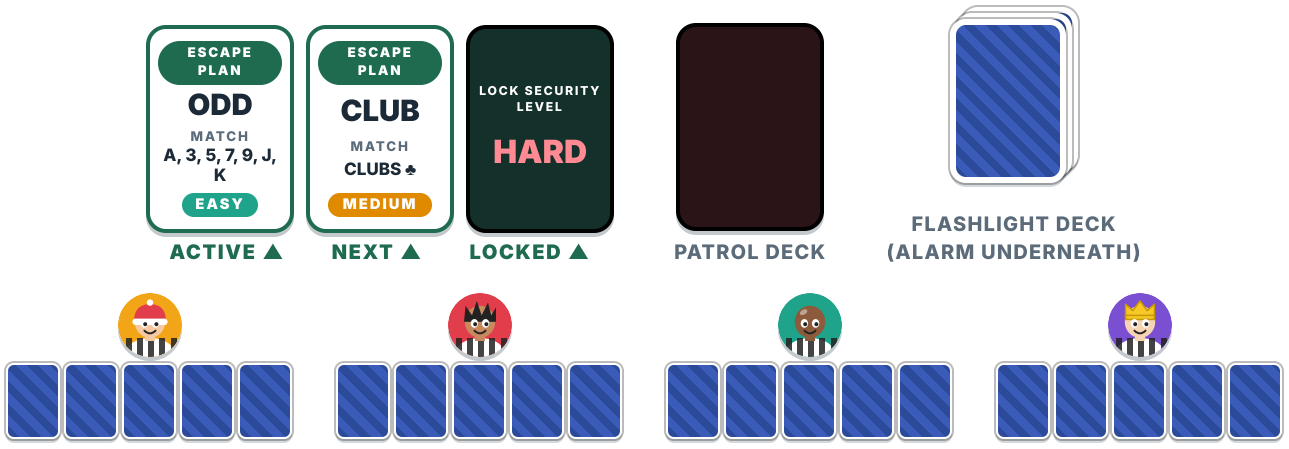
OBSTACLES BY PLAYER COUNT

PLAYERS	OBSTACLES	HARD ADDED
2	8	1
3	5	2
4	3	3

Tip: to raise the difficulty, add 1 extra Obstacle.

Why peek first? Seeing the lock levels before you pick a direction lets the crew decide whether to take the tough locks early or save them for last.

SET-UP FOR 4 PLAYERS



Each inmate holds five cards. The backs shown here face the player; everyone else sees the fronts.

THE BIG TWIST: YOU CAN'T SEE YOUR OWN HAND



Your teammates give you hints (a suit or a rank) through Guard Checks. Keep track of what you've been told.

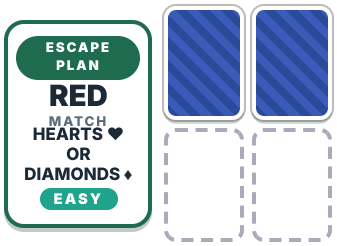
2 ON YOUR TURN

CHOOSE ONE ACTION, THEN OPTIONALLY BREAKTHROUGH

1. Perform **one** of the five actions › **2.** Optionally attempt a **Breakthrough**

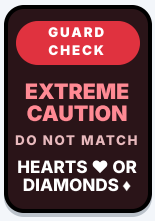
1 Play my part

1. Choose a card from your hand **without looking at it**. Place it face down on an **unoccupied corner of the active Obstacle**.
2. Draw a card from the Flashlight Deck into your hand. Keep it facing away from you.



2 Perform a Guard check

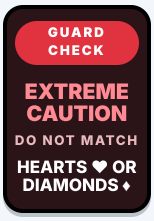
1. Flip the top **Patrol** card and the top **Flashlight** card.
2. Compare the Flashlight card against the Patrol card's criteria.
   - **Fail:** the card *matches* the "DO NOT MATCH" line. Stay silent. Your turn is over.
   - **Pass:** the card does *not* match. Point to a card in a teammate's hand and say either its **suit** or its **rank**.
3. Discard both revealed cards.



VS



PASS ✔
7♠ is not red.
Give a hint!



VS



FAIL ✖
Q♥ is red.
Say nothing.

Reading the Patrol card: the card's coloured label tells you how risky the check is. **Extreme caution** (the card's obstacle side is Easy) is hard to pass because it forbids half the deck. **Relaxed** (the card's obstacle side is Hard) is easy to pass because it only forbids a couple of ranks. The top of the Patrol deck always shows how tough the next check is.

HINTS, IN PRACTICE



"**That one is a club**" (pointing at the 3♣) or "**that one is a 3**". Say a suit *or* a rank, never both. Your teammate remembers it and builds the picture over several turns.

2 ON YOUR TURN, CONTINUED

ACTIONS 3 TO 5 AND THE BREAKTHROUGH

3 Distract

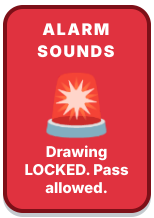
Discard **any** card at the active Obstacle, then choose a Patrol card from the discard pile and shuffle it back into the Patrol deck. Use it to remove a card you know is wrong, and to bring back an easy Guard Check.

4 Riot

Discard **5 cards** from the top of the Flashlight Deck (the deck must have at least 5 cards left), then **swap any two cards**: your own, another player's, or one from the discard pile. At least one has to be in a player's hand. Riots are the best way to move a card to where it's needed.

5 Pass

Only available once the **Alarm Sounds card is visible**, which means the Flashlight Deck has run out. Skip your turn. (Pass is also what you do if you have no other legal action.)



When the Alarm card is revealed, **drawing is locked**. Planting a card no longer replaces it, so your hands shrink as the crew plants.

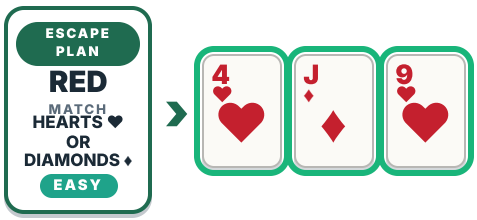
3 BREAKTHROUGH

OPTIONAL, AT THE END OF YOUR TURN

If **each player has planted exactly one card** on the active Obstacle, you may attempt a Breakthrough.

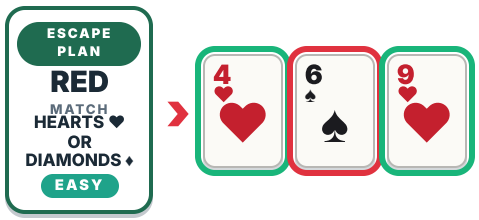
1. Reveal every card planted at the active Obstacle.
2. **All cards meet the condition →** success! Stack the used cards face down on the Obstacle, reveal the next face-down Obstacle (so two are visible), and the next Obstacle in your direction becomes active.
3. **Even one card fails →** the alarm is tripped and **everyone loses immediately**.

SUCCESS · 3 PLAYERS · OBSTACLE: RED



All three are red. On to the next Obstacle!

ALARM! · 3 PLAYERS · OBSTACLE: RED



The 6♠ is black. Everyone loses.

Safety first. Before attempting, make sure every planted card is one you're certain about. If any player is unsure of their own planted card, it's often smarter to let a teammate who *is* certain make the call, or to Distract it. If one planted card is certain to be right, **one verifier** is enough: everyone else's planted cards were seen while being planted.

FREEDOM!



If you have completed **all Obstacles** in the Escape Plan, you win. Enjoy your freedom!

BACK TO YOUR CELLS



If any **Breakthrough fails**, or **all players have no cards in hand** and Obstacles remain, you lose.

CRITICAL REMINDERS

- You see your teammates' hands; **you cannot see your own**.
- Once a card is planted face down, **no one can look at it again**.
- Inmates can only ever see the **active Obstacle and the next one** on the Escape Plan.
- You may only plant cards at the **active Obstacle**.
- Every Obstacle must have **exactly one card from each player** to pass it.
- If any deck is empty, you **cannot reshuffle**.

QUICK REFERENCE: YOUR FIVE ACTIONS

ACTION	WHAT IT DOES	WHEN IT SHINES
Play my part	Plant a blind card face down, then draw	You know your card is right, or you want to cycle in a fresh one
Guard check	Flip Patrol + Flashlight card; if you pass, give a hint	The crew needs information
Distract	Discard a planted card; return a Patrol card to the deck	A planted card is wrong or suspect
Riot	Discard 5 from the deck, swap any two cards	The card an Obstacle needs is in the wrong hand
Pass	Do nothing	Alarm visible and nothing useful to do

TIPS FOR THE CREW

- **Talk in hints, not answers.** Only a suit *or* a rank. Never both, never "that one's fine".
- **Track what you know.** Write the hints on your fingers, or jot them in the margin of a scorepad.
- **Watch every plant.** You'll need to remember every planted card to judge a Breakthrough.
- **Planting a mystery card can be smart.** It's a way to bring fresh cards into your hand, because a teammate can Distract it if it's wrong. Just don't trigger the Breakthrough on it yourself.
- **Pick your direction wisely.** Tackle hard locks while the deck is full, or clear easy ones first and keep hints flowing.
- **Mind the Flashlight Deck.** When it runs dry, drawing stops and hands shrink.

A CARD REFERENCE

EVERY SECURITY CARD, BOTH SIDES

Each Security card is two-sided. Its **obstacle** side (top row of each pair) says what must be planted; its **Guard Check** side (bottom row) says what to avoid. A card that's EASY to match is EXTREME CAUTION to guard-check, and vice versa.

EASY · 6 CARDS

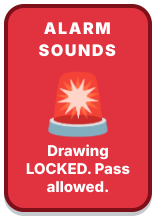
ESCAPE PLAN	MATCH	GUARD CHECK	DO NOT MATCH
ODD	A, 3, 5, 7, 9, J, K	EXTREME CAUTION	A, 3, 5, 7, 9, J, K
HIGH	RANKS 7 THROUGH K	EXTREME CAUTION	RANKS 7 THROUGH K
RED	HEARTS ♥ OR DIAMONDS ♦	EXTREME CAUTION	HEARTS ♥ OR DIAMONDS ♦
BLACK	SPADES ♠ OR CLUBS ♣	EXTREME CAUTION	SPADES ♠ OR CLUBS ♣
EVEN	2, 4, 6, 8, 10, Q	EXTREME CAUTION	2, 4, 6, 8, 10, Q
LOW	RANKS A THROUGH 6	EXTREME CAUTION	RANKS A THROUGH 6

MEDIUM · 6 CARDS

ESCAPE PLAN	MATCH	GUARD CHECK	DO NOT MATCH
HEART	HEARTS ♥	MEDIUM	HEARTS ♥
DIAMOND	DIAMONDS ♦	MEDIUM	DIAMONDS ♦
SPADE	SPADES ♠	MEDIUM	SPADES ♠
CLUB	CLUBS ♣	MEDIUM	CLUBS ♣
FACE	JACK, QUEEN, OR KING	MEDIUM	JACK, QUEEN, OR KING
A, 2, 3	A, 2, OR 3	MEDIUM	A, 2, OR 3

HARD · 5 CARDS

ESCAPE PLAN	MATCH	GUARD CHECK	DO NOT MATCH
Q, K	QUEEN OR KING	RELAXED	QUEEN OR KING
A, J	ACE OR JACK	RELAXED	ACE OR JACK
8 OR 9	8 OR 9	RELAXED	8 OR 9
6 OR 7	6 OR 7	RELAXED	6 OR 7
4 OR 5	4 OR 5	RELAXED	4 OR 5



ALARM SOUNDS

RANKS

Ace is low: A = 1, J = 11, Q = 12, K = 13. **ODD** = A, 3, 5, 7, 9, J, K. **EVEN** = 2, 4, 6, 8, 10, Q. **LOW** = A through 6. **HIGH** = 7 through K.